Aurora and the Curious Capybara

The Woods Are Calling

Aurora and the Curious Capybara - The Woods Are Calling

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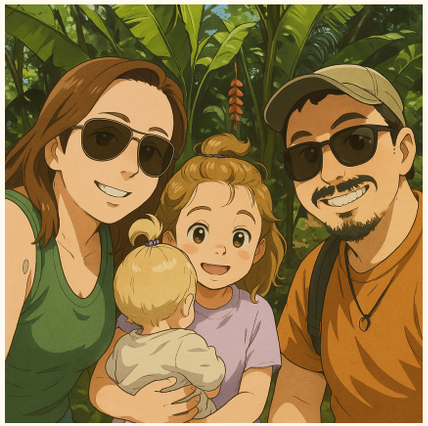


Amid the noise of the world, you two are my refuge, the place I will always return to.

Morning sunshine warmed her room with gentle golden light.
A snail was pictured on her screen, its round shell curled up tight.
She brushed the picture with her hand. "Where might its home be?"
A voice called from the garden, "Aurora! Come and see!"

Her best friend, Curious Capybara, crouched beside the trail.
She watched an ant with one small leaf. "It's carrying a sail!
How does it lift a leaf so big? Come look! It's walking past!"
Aurora put the screen away. "I'm coming! I'll be fast!"

In her dress and lilac sneakers, Aurora hurried near.
"Another ant! And one more there! They're all along here!"
Her friend was pointing down the line. Aurora bent to see.
"So many things I hadn't seen, right here in front of me!"

Capybara had a backpack, soft and round and green,
shaped just like a turtle's shell, the sweetest ever seen.
Water, cloth, a tub, a folded bag were packed away.
"I've brought the things we'll need," she said. "I want a whole big day!"

"How many games can fit inside one whole day of play?"
Aurora grinned. "Let's find that out! Let's go and see today!"
Her mother heard them talking and came over to the gate.
"Your dad is in the garden. Tell him first, before it's late."

"We're going with our friends," she said, "and Old Owl knows the way.
We'll keep right to the woodland trail, wherever we may play."
"Be back when sunshine starts to fade," her mother said. "Don't wait.
Come home together down the trail. We'll meet you at the gate."

The garden beds were close to home, in tidy little rows.
Dad watered all the lettuce with his gently spraying hose.
Aurora walked beside the beds, where she would crush no green.
Her friend saw leaves poke through the soil. "What's hiding there, unseen?"

"Do those leaves have a little house? Who's living down below?"
Dad pulled a carrot from the earth. "That's where its roots can grow!"
Aurora saw the orange carrot, dirt along its head.
"It hasn't had a wash!" she laughed. "It just rolled out of bed!"

Dad laughed and washed his hands, then washed the things they'd picked that day.
He made a snack for both his helpers, packed and tucked away.
He filled their tub with bread and fruit, enough for friends to share.
"And check you've brought your water, too, before you leave from here."

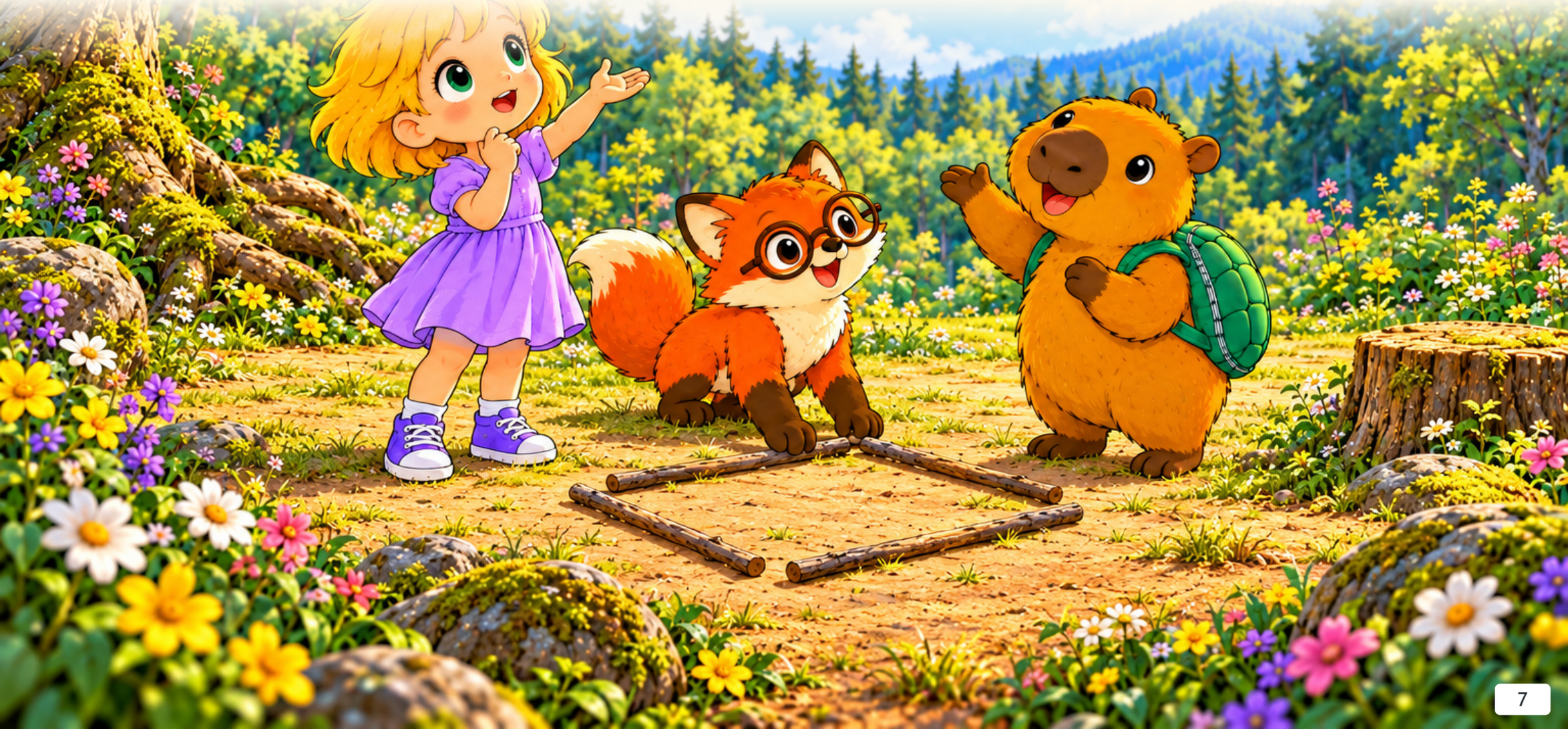
He brought some tangerines from trees that grew beside the bed.
Capybara sniffed one. "This one's coming too!" she said.
Dad added one small flashlight. "For the walk back, if it's dim.
Keep everything shut tight and safe." They packed it all with him.

Beyond the garden, down the trail, the woods were bright with flowers.
A butterfly went floating past, as quiet as the hours.
On leaves, on branches, on the ground, wherever they could peep,
were wings and tiny walking feet that wouldn't stay asleep.

The cool earth smelled so fresh and good. The leaves swayed in the breeze.
It whispered, softly, softly, through the bushes and the trees.
Aurora spread her arms out wide. "It all wants us to play!"
"Where shall we start?" her best friend asked. "There's so much here today!"

The trail led to a clearing with a sunny patch of ground,
with flowers growing at the edge and green grass all around.
There stood Fox, his glasses sitting neatly on his nose,
laying down four little sticks. How carefully he chose!

"My make-believe house goes right here!" He pointed to his square.
Aurora asked, "What of the roof? What will you put up there?"
"I'll make the floor, then work that out. First things first," said he.
Capybara peered inside. "Is there room for you and me?"



Koala sat upon a low log, with his snack wrapped tight.
He listened to each little sound, alert and sitting upright.
A leaf moved. Up he pulled his feet. What was that on the ground?
A grasshopper went HOP! HOP! HOP! and took another bound.

"It jumps so high! Will it jump here? Will it jump in my ear?"
Aurora pointed to a leaf. "It's landed over there.
I think it likes that old leaf best. There's lots of room to stay."
Koala watched from far enough. "Then I'll sit here. Okay."

Sloth lay stretched along a root, within a shady spot.
"Good morning..." came her happy voice. "Have you seen what I've got?
A tiny drop upon this leaf. It doesn't want to go.
It sits right on the very tip. It likes to balance so."

Aurora and her friend bent low. The sky shone in that bead.
"A whole small sky fits in a drop! Look closely! Yes, indeed!"
Sloth moved the leaf. The little drop fell softly to the ground.
"Oh dear! I've lost my tiny sky!" She laughed at what she'd found.

Old Owl sat high above his friends, with feathers soft and brown.
He wore the sort of sleepy frown that pulls your eyebrows down.
"A roofless house? A sky on leaves? Such chatter! Such a peep!
If I shut both my eyes, will you let me get some sleep?"

"A whole day out to play!" his friend explained. "We've packed supplies!"
"And water? Have you packed it?" asked Old Owl, opening his eyes.
"Right here, beside our snack!" She showed the tub. He looked below.
"Then wait for me. I'm coming too. These are the paths I know."

Fox left the sticks to mark the house. "We'll finish when we're back!"
His friends agreed. Aurora pointed down the winding track.
"Where shall we go?" she asked Old Owl. He turned his beak to peek.
"Just follow down this woodland trail. It takes us to the creek."

Six friends went through the woods, each in a very different way.
Aurora hopped along the path, with room enough to play.
Capybara asked; Fox watched; Koala looked around.
Sloth took her time to notice things, on branches and the ground.

Before they saw the creek, they heard its water rushing through.
It ran between the stones all day, with more and more to do.
One little sound was soft and low; another loud and clear.
Capybara stopped to listen. "I can hear it better here!"

They stayed on firm ground, out of water, not leaning out to see.
Owl watched them from a nearby branch, as watchful as could be.
"Glug-glug!" she copied from the creek. Fox tried a gurgle too.
It started as a water sound... and ended, "Ah-CHOO!"

"You're water with a cold!" she laughed. Fox wiped his dripping nose.
"I only meant to sound like that! That's how a gurgle goes!"
Sloth softly tapped a leaf. "My music... starts out very small.
It only needs some falling water... for a waterfall."

A CROAK! came from the creekside plants. Koala looked up high.
"I think that came from down below!" he said, still watching sky.
A frog appeared upon a wet rock. What a funny little thing!
It gave another mighty CROAK! What a way for frogs to sing!

Capybara moved up close, but let the frog sit free.
"How does a creature quite so small make such a sound?" asked she.
"It's how he calls," Old Owl explained. "His friends across the way
can hear him from the other bank. It's how frogs have their say."

Koala tried a little "cr..." that sounded like a wheeze.
He tried again. "Cr-ACH!" Just like a frog about to sneeze!
He laughed. "Did you hear that croak? How funny it can be!"
The frog hopped off. "Oh dear! I don't think he likes me!"

"He's off to do his own frog things," Owl said. "Now let him go.
He didn't come to join our game. There's much we do not know."
"He must have friends of his own!" Aurora smiled to see.
Her best friend nodded. "Yes, of course. A bit like you and me!"

They followed on beside the creek. The water led the way
toward a little shining pond. They walked without delay.
Between the trunks, a patch of blue came sparkling into view.
A few more steps... and there it lay! They'd reached the pond. It's true!

A waterfall splashed down through rounded stones with a bubbling sound.
Its tiny waves spread into rings that rippled all around.
The dragonflies flew here and there, their wings so thin and clear.
Capybara watched their different flights as they went darting near.

"More woods down there!" Fox pointed to the water, smooth as glass.
Aurora saw her own face there. A little wave went past.
It wrinkled up her picture. "Look! My nose has slipped away!
It's straight up here, but down in there, it's pointing quite that way!"

They sat upon the dry bank, with some room to rest their feet.
Capybara opened up her pack. "It's time to eat!"
Aurora spread the cloth out. Fox held one end nice and steady.
Koala saw the tub. "Is all the fruit inside it ready?"

"Ready to come out!" she laughed, and opened it with care.
The bread and fruit were safe inside, all ready now to share.
They each took some and had a drink. Old Owl came over too.
He didn't want to miss the snack! Well, really, would you?

Capybara peeled her tangerine and shared the pieces round.
She put the peel inside her little bag, not on the ground.
Koala took his own leaves from the wrapping he had brought.
"My snack came here with me!" he said, and found a sitting spot.

Sloth looked up. "A rabbit... in the sky! What do you think of that?"
Aurora saw the cloud. "And look! It's wearing quite a hat!"
Fox straightened up his glasses. "I see one long loaf instead."
Old Owl grumbled, "What I see is someone's half-eaten bread!"

The wind stretched out the rabbit-cloud and pulled it long and thin.
"It's turned into a fish!" Aurora said with quite a grin.
Her friend tipped back her head. "A duck is resting in the air!"
"Then let's go swimming!" said the girl, and waddled off from there.

Upon the DRY ground, arms tucked in, she waddled, duck by duck.
Fox followed close behind her, trying out his walking luck.
Sloth smiled. "My duck... goes slowly." Koala looked down with a sigh.
"My duck forgot to swim!" he said. "Perhaps his feet know why!"

"Ducks!" Old Owl watched the wobbly line. "What a curious sight!
Five ducks are waddling on the ground in the middle of broad daylight!"
Capybara spread her paws. "Would you like to play? Come try!"
He turned his head. "I'm an OWL! I cannot swim. Not I!"

But down he flew and took two funny steps from side to side.
"Look! A duck in owl disguise!" Aurora laughed and cried.
He smoothed his feathers, looking grand. "I'm checking where we go.
Please carry on. I'm checking paths. That's all you need to know."

Then everyone sat quietly. They listened to it all:
one bird sang very softly; one gave out a louder call.
Aurora leaned against her friend, her feet upon the cloth.
No need to hurry. No big plan. They rested there with Sloth.

"It's getting warm," Aurora said. Her friend shut both her eyes.
"This breeze feels good!" she murmured, with a little happy sigh.
A leaf brushed through her fur. She laughed. A tickle! What a treat!
Aurora reached to feel it too. "That breeze feels soft and sweet!"

The sun had passed its highest point. The afternoon was bright.
Fox thought about the house they'd left. "Our floor is waiting, right?
Shall we go back and finish?" Capybara shut her pack. "I want to see how it turns out! Come on! Let's all go back!"

They packed the cloth and tub away, and left no litter there.
Owl led them down the very same trail, and watched them all with care.
The frog had left the creekside rock. Koala called, "CROAK! See?
This time I did it! That big frog-like sound came out of ME!"

The four sticks in the clearing still lay just where Fox had planned.
"Let's start!" he said, and pointed to the square upon the land.
Two little stones now marked the door. Aurora brought a pile
of dry leaves for a cushion. "Come and sit a little while!"

Capybara placed one leaf beside the door. "Our bell goes here!
Touch gently. Please don't step on it when you come walking near."
Sloth tapped the leaf. "Ding-dong... May I come in?" she asked that day.
Aurora opened up a door... that wasn't there, to play.

"What of the roof?" her friend looked up. Aurora waved up high.
"That cloud will make a perfect roof!" She pointed to the sky.
"But when it floats away, won't all our roof go floating too?"
Fox laughed. "Then there's another cloud to make a roof that's new!"

Koala chose a little corner, close beside the door.
"No lock upon the doorway! I can go right out once more!"
He put a little leaf beside the cushion, off to one side.
"A grasshopper's seat... if he won't jump on ME when he's inside!"

Sloth made a bed of fallen leaves, then stretched out for a rest.
She crossed her paws. "My mattress... is the very, very best."
Aurora knocked. "Is there some room for visitors today?"
"There is... but softly, please. My bed is lovely... Come this way."

Aurora sat beside her. Capybara came to see.
Fox made some room. "Come have a look! There's room for you and me!
My window goes right here!" He pointed proudly from the floor.
"The WHOLE woods through one window!" laughed Koala by the door.

Owl settled on a nearby stump beside their house of air.
"A house without a single wall! A lovely breeze in there!"
"And where will your room go?" his friend asked, looking up with care.
He eyed the stump. "Right here, where no one's chattering in my ear!"

Aurora came up close. "Then you can be our lookout too!"
"I've been that since you all arrived! Who's been looking after you?"
A little twig blocked up the door. He moved it with his beak.
"There. Now you all can walk right through. I'll stay here while you peek."

Fox knocked upon the make-believe door, his voice a rumbling growl.
"Good afternoon! I'm a GIANT! May I come in?" he howled.
Aurora laughed. "A giant? You're a little one, I see!"
He rose up on his toes. "Well, look how tall I now can be!"

Capybara offered him a leaf. "Some bread to help you grow!
It's only make-believe, of course. We're pretending, as you know."
Fox took three great pretend bites, then gave his feet a stare.
"I'm so big now, my feet stretch into TWO streets over there!"

Koala peeped around the door. "I live next to that great
big giant. Please don't step upon my house beside your gate.
It's very small. It's just right here!" Fox took the smallest tread.
"A tiny house? I understand. Small steps it is!" he said.

Sloth was a queen without a crown, stretched in her shady seat.
"My kingdom... has a pillow... and some shade to beat the heat."
Capybara carried mail. Aurora cooked that day.
And Owl? Still Owl, keeping watch on everyone at play.

The clearing's flowers shone with gold. The woods glowed orange too.
Aurora raised her head. "The sun is sinking out of view!"
Her friend recalled their promise. "Time to go before it's late.
Your parents will be waiting. Let's get back to that front gate."

They left the loose leaves where they'd found them, under trees nearby,
and moved the sticks off of the trail so feet could travel by.
Koala looked. No grasshopper had come to share their rest.
"I'll leave your cushion in the grass. Come try it. It's the best."

The trees looked different on the way, with evening in their light.
Koala held his paws up close. "It's getting dark. Is that all right?
Is there much farther still to walk?" Owl pointed through the trees.
"Not far. We see the house from here. Come look between those leaves."

Capybara took the flashlight out. Aurora held it low
and switched it on to light the ground and show which way to go.
They stayed together, walking calmly down the homeward track.
The garden came in sight. Mom stood beside the gate. "You're back!"

The friends came home to Mom and Dad beside the garden gate.
"How was your whole big day?" Dad asked.
Aurora couldn't wait!
"A house without a wall! A frog! Some ducks walked in a row!
And Old Owl turned into a duck... a little bit, you know!"

"I WAS checking on the trail!" Owl grumbled by her side.
Fox gave a quiet chuckle as the night grew deep and wide.
Mom sat upon the garden bench. The others gathered near.
A cricket called out from the woods. One answered, right from here.

The first star twinkled overhead. A second gleamed far away.
Capybara asked the question from the start of their big day:
"How many games can fit inside one whole day of play?"
Aurora hugged her friend. "So many! I still want more today!"

She looked toward the trail, then at the stars that shone so bright.
The woods were big! So much to see, to left and right!
"More tomorrow?" asked Aurora, not quite ready to be through.
"Yes! The woods are calling, Aurora. They're calling me and you!"

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The Woods Are Calling

How many games can fit into a day in the woods? Aurora and her best friend, Curious Capybara, are about to find out! With Fox, Koala, Sloth and Old Owl, they discover sounds, dream up characters and even build a house without walls. From the vegetable garden to the little pond, from morning sunshine to a sky full of stars, meet a group of friends who find adventure in the smallest things.